

Medford Public Schools  
Medford, Massachusetts

Medford School Committee

Committee of the Whole  
September 28, 2015

Minutes

The Medford School Committee of the Whole was called to order at 7:05 p.m. by Chairperson John Falco.

The following members were present: John Falco, Ann Marie Cugno, Erin DiBenedetto, Robert Skerry Jr. and Paulette Van der Kloot. Also Superintendent Roy Belson, Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson and Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell. Presenters included Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli, ELA Director Nichole Chiesa, Math Director Carolyn Joy, and Science Coordinator Rocco Cieri. Also in attendance were school principals and departmental administrators. There were several members of the public also in attendance.

All rose to salute the flag.

Chairperson Falco stated that the purpose of the meeting was to review and discuss the 2015 MCAS scores for Medford.

Superintendent Belson provided an introductory overview. He explained that the comparability of this years scores are not possible to any great extent because of the dual administration of MCAS and PARCC.

He discussed several factors that impact performance including:

- Number of students taking the test
- Demographics
- Relative difficulty of test at different grade levels
- Teacher factors
- Loss of time due to snow days

The Superintendent then identified several key points regarding this years district performance:

1. Grade 10 continues to exceed the state in attainment of Proficient and above for ELA and mathematics and meeting the science competency requirement.
2. Overall growth percentiles of students show better than average

3. There is positive evidence of programs supporting the curriculum and leading to higher levels of student achievement. This is seen in grade 3 ELA test results. The *Journeys* program has been in place since this group was in grade 1. One of the most formative years for language development is grade 1.
4. Curriculum decisions such as the grade 9 change in science from Earth Science to Introductory to Physics has led to a 97% rate of student passing science competency determination in grade 9.
5. Data shows students make gains in performance as they exit a grade span and move to the next level.

Proficient and Above

ELA

|          |     |    |         |     |
|----------|-----|----|---------|-----|
| grade 3  | 52% | by | grade 5 | 59% |
| grade 6  | 65% | by | grade 8 | 73% |
| grade 10 | 92% |    |         |     |

Mathematics

|          |     |    |         |     |
|----------|-----|----|---------|-----|
| grade 3  | 59% | by | grade 5 | 50% |
| grade 6  | 40% | by | grade 8 | 47% |
| grade 10 | 80% |    |         |     |

6. Cusp scores show significant number of students close (2-3 points) from Proficient
7. Grade 3 is first cohort who has had curricula in ELA and mathematics based on new frameworks from the beginning of their public school experience. Older grade levels are tested on new frameworks yet their exposure to this curriculum is less limited due to the implementation of the frameworks.

The Superintendent then asked Deputy Superintendent Nelson to begin the detailed analysis of the 2015 results.

Documents (see attached) were distributed for all three MCAS subject areas.

Deputy Superintendent Nelson responded to an inquiry by Member DiBenedetto regarding comparisons by explaining that because this years assessments were split between PARCC and MCAS that the usual comparisons are not valid.

Dr. Nicole Chiesa, Director of ELA provided the highlights of that subject area. (see attached) She also provided information on the “cusp” scores. These scores identify students who are in the very high “needs improvement” category (2-4 points below proficient)

Member Van der Kloot asked if an analysis of last year’s “cusp” students showed them moving up to proficient.

Dr. Chiesa responded that an analysis of the “Growth Scores” would provide a general answer to that question. Specifically if there is solid growth and the percentage of students scoring proficient and advanced increases then it is likely that those on the cusp have moved up. This is best evidenced by looking at a cohort analysis.

Member Van der Kloot was also interested to determine the best way to move more students into the ‘advanced’ category.

Member Cugno commented that the state’s rollout of this year’s information is very complicated and confusing. We don’t know what we are getting because the state has not released all the information.

It was explained that the subgroups often contained students who were in more than one category. For example: a student could be low income, ELL, and Sped all at the same time. That student’s performance would be reflected in all of the subgroups not just one.

Math Director Carolyn Joy began her presentation of key points (see attached)

Member DiBenedetto asked about the middle school math program. Director Joy responded that we will be making a decision on a new program this year. However, teachers have sufficient materials to do their work right now.

Director Joy indicated that she would do the following with her teachers based on this year’s results:

- Grade by grade item analysis
- Overall data trend analysis
- Work on reviewing materials to ensure mastering through retest is through a cumulative learning approach

Member Skerry felt we should be doing more with the analysis of subgroup performance at each grade level.

Member Van der Kloot wanted to take a macro look at our results. She asked the three department directors to identify what they believed were the strengths and weaknesses.

Dr. Chiesa responded as follows:

- Writing at the secondary level was good
- Reading at the secondary level needed more work
- Opposite was true at the elementary level
- Currently looking at a new graphic organizer tool

Director Joy offered:

- Less students in warning
- Growth data is consistent with state on above

Coordinator Cieri reported:

- 97% of ninth graders achieved the competency requirement on the first try.
- Our science scores are better than the state
- Department will be looking at item and strand analysis more closely especially at the middle school level

Mr. Cieri reviewed the highlights of his department (see attached)

Director of Curriculum and Instruction Bernadette Ricciardelli provided a limited look into comparable districtwide area data. However, this limited chart did not factor in a full grade progression that would illuminate longitudinal growth.

Deputy Superintendent Nelson indicated that there were good results for the two subgroups identified by the state as narrowing the achievement gap namely Hispanic and Afro-American.

Member DiBenedetto asked about other assessments that are used and requested information from the three presenting department heads. Dr. Chiesa referenced the DRAs and Fountas Pinnell as examples. Director Joy spoke about benchmarking with our new programs.

The Administration will provide follow up reports to the School Committee as additional analysis is completed.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno the meeting was adjourned at 8:35 p.m.

Respectfully submitted,

Robert E. Skerry Jr.  
Secretary